

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

What's News

Business & Finance

- ◆ **Corporate America** pulled back from diversity programs in 2024 under pressure from activists and will face a more-powerful challenger in Trump in 2025. **A1**
- ◆ **China recently flaunted** the ways in which it could hit back in the event of a new trade war with the U.S., but using such tools too aggressively risks backfiring on Beijing. **A1**
- ◆ **New-vehicle prices** are expected to ease further in 2025, with discounts continuing to flow as many automakers return to pre-pandemic inventory levels. **B1**
- ◆ **Investors who entered** each of the past two years brimming with optimism about U.S. Treasuries and other high-quality debt only to be disappointed are now far more guarded. **B1**
- ◆ **Suntory is preparing** for a rising risk of global trade wars by stockpiling in Europe, considering importing more U.K. scotch into the region and changing its sales focus in the U.S. **B3**
- ◆ **Big Lots, which filed** for bankruptcy in September, said it reached an agreement with Gordon Brothers that would keep hundreds of stores open and save thousands of jobs. **B3**
- ◆ **U.S. crude-oil inventories** fell more than expected the week before last and product stocks were mixed as refineries raised their capacity use. **B3**
- ◆ **U.S. regulators and** lawmakers are proposing new rules to protect hospitals from cyberattacks in 2025, but small healthcare providers are concerned that they can't afford to comply. **B4**

World-Wide

- ◆ **Former President** Jimmy Carter, the Georgia peanut farmer whose one term in the Oval Office was plagued by problems at home and abroad but who was awarded the Nobel Peace Prize after he left office, died at the age of 100. **A1**
- ◆ **International** investigators worked to pinpoint what caused the fiery crash of a South Korean passenger plane that killed nearly all of the 181 people on board. **A1**
- ◆ **Azerbaijan's president** accused Russia of trying to cover up its role in the crash of an airliner that killed 38 people on Christmas Day. **A6**
- ◆ **A special election** to fill a congressional seat in New York state being vacated by Republican Rep. Elise Stefanik looms as an early test of Democrats' plans for escaping the political wilderness. **A5**
- ◆ **Justice Department** lawyers who have angered Trump and his allies face tough decisions about whether to stay in government and how to best protect themselves from threats of retribution. **A4**
- ◆ **Former soccer player** Mikheil Kavelashvili was formally inaugurated as president of Georgia, cementing the ruling party's grip on power. **A7**
- ◆ **Rising tensions** with China are prompting Washington to revisit America's history as a nation of seafaring traders protected by a powerful Navy. **A3**
- ◆ **Died: Jimmy Carter**, 100, 39th president of the United States. **A1** ... **Charles Dolan**, 98, cable-television pioneer. **B1** ... **Warren Upton**, 105, oldest survivor of the 1941 Japanese attack on Pearl Harbor. **A2**

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Former President Carter, Nobel Winner, Dies at 100

By CAMERON McWHIRTER AND BETSY MCKAY

ATLANTA—Former President Jimmy Carter, the Georgia peanut farmer whose one term in the Oval Office was plagued by problems at home and abroad but who was awarded the Nobel Peace Prize after he left office, has died.

The Carter Center con-

firmed the death on X Sunday.

He was 100 years old, the longest-lived former president in the country's history. He had been in hospice since February 2023.

The 39th president's sole term in office was marred by a listless economy and stubborn inflation, squabbles within his party, gridlock in Congress and the seizure of U.S. hos-

tages in Iran. Considered a long-shot Democratic candidate when he announced his bid, Carter would broker a historic peace treaty between Israel and Egypt and set in motion other changes that would dominate global politics in subsequent years.

Many of the achievements for which he was recognized

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Jimmy Carter, shown in 1977, was the longest-living ex-president.

South Korea Jet Crash Kills 179



Rescue and inspection workers examined wreckage of the Jeju Air plane at Muan International Airport in South Korea on Sunday.

Boeing 737-800 operated by Jeju Air skidded, slammed into barrier; 2 survive

International investigators worked to pinpoint what caused the fiery crash of a South Korean passenger plane that killed nearly all of the 181 people on board, in one of the deadliest aviation disasters in years.

The aircraft skidded off the

By Dasl Yoon, Timothy W. Martin and Andrew Tangel

runway, collided with a concrete barrier and burst into flames as it attempted to land Sunday at an airport in Muan

County, in the country's southwest, just after 9 a.m. local time. The plane, operated by South Korea's Jeju Air, was a Boeing 737-800, a workhorse of commercial air travel.

Shortly before landing, the control tower warned of a possible bird strike and the

Jeju Air pilots issued a may-day. Aviation safety experts said a severe bird strike could disable both engines as well as mechanical systems used to lower landing gear. Videos showed the jet's landing gear wasn't deployed as the plane

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DEI Upheaval Is Set To Intensify in 2025

By THEO FRANCIS AND CHIP CUTTER

Corporate America pulled back on diversity programs in 2024 under pressure from activists. In the new year, it will face an even more powerful challenger.

President-elect Donald Trump's second administration is gearing up to end diversity, equity and inclusion, or DEI, policies in dozens of government and business programs after many of the same concepts came under attack at some of the biggest U.S. companies.

"The pendulum is swinging

back and swinging back very hard against DEI," said Mike Davis, a former Senate lawyer who runs the Article III Project, a conservative legal advocacy group, who is a close outside adviser to Trump. "Until DEI is eradicated from society there's still work to be done."

Wisconsin Institute for Law & Liberty, which has sued companies over DEI policies, is pointing to 61 federal programs it considers ripe for litigation and elimination, including technical assistance for minority farmers and contracting preferences for minority-owned law firms helping to collect U.S.

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One Place to Dunk on NBA Star: A New York City Chess Board

7-Foot-3 Victor Wembanyama stopped in at Manhattan park for different kind of 1-on-1

By JOSHUA ROBINSON

Max Haskell was on his regular grocery run in New York's East Village on Saturday when he pulled out his phone and saw a tweet that stopped him in his tracks.

NBA superstar Victor Wembanyama had posted out of the blue that he was just a few blocks away. Not only that, but the 7-foot-3 reigning Rookie of the Year was offering to take on all-comers, one-on-one, in Wash-

ington Square Park.

The twist was that they wouldn't be playing basketball. "Who wants to meet me at the SW corner of Washington Square Park to play chess?" Wembanyama posted shortly after 9:30 a.m. "I'm there."

Haskell, a 25-year-old local who has lived in Russia and the U.K., knew exactly what he had to do.

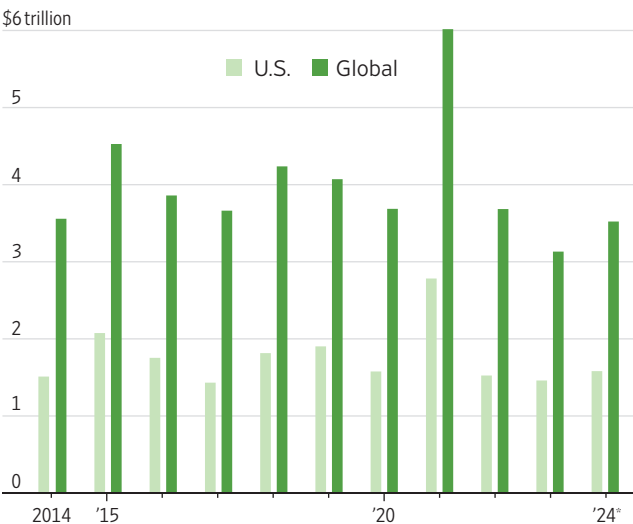
He abandoned his basket of groceries, hopped on a Citi Bike, and

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Deal Hopes Rise for New Year

Wall Street is optimistic that dealmaking will rebound in 2025 with a buoyant stock market, declining interest rates and President-elect Donald Trump's lighter-regulation agenda. **B1**

Annual M&A deal volume*



*As of Dec. 26
Source: Dealogic

INSIDE



SPORTS

Texas Longhorns return to their roots, set for a deep playoff run. **A14**



OBITUARY

Charles Dolan, a cable-TV pioneer who launched HBO, is dead at 98. **B1**

Big Saudi Project Puts Workers In Danger

By RORY JONES AND ELIOT BROWN

Billed as a futuristic city-state with dazzling architecture including parallel 106-mile-long skyscrapers taller than the Empire State Building, Neom is the centerpiece of Saudi Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman's plans to transform his oil-rich country into a modern diversified economy.

But for its 100,000 workers, the world's biggest construction project has been more like a dystopia.

Neom employees have reported incidents of gang rape, suicide, attempted murder and drug dealing on the site, slated to cover an area the size of Massachusetts. Last year, a McKinsey consultant died in a head-on crash at night even after safety staff warned Neom management about the danger of driving late on the region's roads. Laborers at one of the migrant worker camps mounted a violent protest over frustration with food. Children as young as 8 have been caught driving trucks.

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Retaliation Over Trade Poses Risk For China

By JASON DOUGLAS

SINGAPORE—In the weeks since the election, China has flaunted the ways in which it could hit back in the event of a new trade war with the U.S., including everything from choking off the metals needed for everyday products to punishing U.S. companies that do business in China.

But using such tools too aggressively risks backfiring on Beijing.

The big danger is that taking shots at Western companies and restricting exports of critical minerals and other essentials will only encourage the U.S. and its allies to double down on their efforts to untangle their economies from China's.

That would spell trouble for Beijing as long as it remains wedded to an economic model that relies heavily on selling its goods to Western consumers.

While China can inflict pain on the U.S. with economic tools at its disposal, it is more likely to wield them sparingly, according to analysts. Instead, Beijing could use the measures to force talks to negotiate a truce with President-elect Donald Trump should he follow through on his promise to impose 60% tariffs on Chinese imports.

"Just using these tools willy-nilly doesn't make sense. You have to be driving towards an outcome, which is some sort of negotiation," said Logan

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